CASE STUDY #3

FAMILY PLANNING, CHRISTIAN MISSIONARY, GENDER AND HUMAN RIGHTS

Sub-Saharan Africa has an acute human resource crisis. The World Health Organization defined 57 countries as having a critical labor shortage, and 36 of those countries are in sub-Saharan Africa. The reasons for this have to do with both input and output issues, including training, recruitment, productivity, motivation, quality, attrition, retention, and migration issues. Current response to human resource problems – particularly those related to income and performance – is often piecemeal and improvised. Faith-based organizations from the United States have developed strategies to address human rights and human resource crisis across Africa.

Ministries in Africa include:

AIDS prevention and care
Business development
Community development
Healthcare
Orphan care
Pregnancy crisis centers
Social welfare ministries
Women's ministries
Youth ministries

Sub-Saharan Africa's population is divided between followers of Islam and the traditional Christian church. While the use of contraception among Sub-Saharan women has reached an impressive 66.5%, only 30% of Sub-Saharan women of reproductive age use a modern method of birth control.

Christian leaders are concerned about regional trends of a declining Christian population, and other trends that may negatively impact their economic and other ministries in Africa. They have asked you to review this Pew Research

Center report so that you understand their concerns.

THE FUTURE OF WORLD RELIGIONS: POPULATION GROWTH PROJECTIONS, 2010-2050: SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA

Missionaries are working with Sub-Saharan Africa's religious leaders on issues such as family planning and reproductive health programs. In 2010, Sub-Saharan Africa's faith-based organizations visited 100 rural communities with members of various governments and other religious and political leaders.

The commitment of Sub-Saharan African health workers to family planning projects, and their willingness to collaborate with religious leaders and NGOs, were fundamental factors in the successes they've had. The language used surrounding family planning issues was also found to be important. Sub-Saharan health workers found that terms such as 'family welfare' or 'family health' were more amenable to their constituents than 'family planning.'

Christian missionaries, along with several U.S. universities, are studying: 1) how family size affects gender equality, human income, and family health, and 2) the effects of harmful traditional practices, such as female genital cutting, and early marriage and childbirth, on sexuality and gender violence. One of the subject matter experts on Africa and population health recommended that you review this article as it may help your team develop recommendations for this complex case.

FERTILITY TRANSITION: IS SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA DIFFERENT?

At the end of this study, religious leaders from Sub-Saharan Africa have asked your team to develop a strategic plan to address these issues, particularly gender violence and gender inequality. The religious leaders have mixed views on traditional practices such as female genital cutting, early marriage, and abortion. The Bible and Koran are often used to justify such practices; however, gender violence, rape, and unsafe abortions are often undesired outcomes of these traditional practices.

One of the reasons the religious leaders were open to these practices was their observation that family planning and reproductive health services fit into Sub-Saharan culture, and that these services benefited both public health and economic situation such as more women taking on non-traditional careers such as medicine and engineering.